

Eating habits

Insects eat a wide range of foods. Some are meat-eaters and some are vegetarians, but most spend their time eating. Insects have mouthparts for either biting and chewing or piercing and sucking.

Meat-eaters

Many insects eat other insects and have to find cunning ways to catch their meals. This praying mantis hides among leaves and then strikes.

The praying mantis can sit still for a long time waiting for its meal to walk past.

This hummingbird moth has a long tongue to suck nectar with. It feeds while it is flying.



Vegetarians

Most insects are vegetarians and munch or sip constantly during their lives. Some like to bite and chew food such as leaves; others suck liquid, such as flower nectar, through their tongues.

Antlion larva is sometimes called a "doodlebug".



Meaty meals

The antlion larva buries itself underground with its open mouth facing the sky and simply waits. When an ant runs over the hole, it falls straight into the antlion's jaws and is eaten swiftly.